extend to vigorously pursuing the movement in Pakistan, where Taliban leaders were allowed to resettle in the Tribal Areas and Quetta (the capital of Balochistan province). During its subsequent counter-terrorism campaign the Musharraf regime spared the Taliban, which in turn followed a policy of abjuring attacks in Pakistan. Nor did the US, after demanding that Pakistan abandon support for the Taliban in Afghanistan, force the issue. Pakistan was making an effort to capture or kill al-Qaeda operatives on its soil in the early years after 9/11, which was then America's top priority. The overriding primacy the US gave to al-Qaeda allowed the Taliban space to regenerate. It began redeveloping its networks in Afghanistan and laying the foundation in 2003 for a future escalation.[57] The insurgency there was showing signs of growth in 2004, but even as late as 2005 the political and security situation had not yet deteriorated. Raiding into Afghanistan from Pakistan began in earnest that year. According to Ashley Tellis, an expert on the region who has advised the US government, it was at this point that pressure on Musharraf to interdict the Taliban became the subject of high-level US demarches to Pakistan.[58] By this time Islamabad's calculus favored increasing support for the Taliban, rather than cracking down on it.

Pakistan had supported the Taliban during the 1990s in the hopes of securing strategic depth in Afghanistan, partially as a place to train militants for operations against India and primarily for use in the event of a war with India. Doing so was also a means of negating Indian influence in Afghanistan, which stoked Pakistani fears of encirclement. Nor was Pakistan alone in supporting a proxy force in Afghanistan, where India had supported the Northern Alliance, though not nearly to the same extent. India not only maintained relations with some former Northern Alliance commanders, but in the decade following the Taliban's overthrow in 2001 it also poured in close to 1 billion dollars in development aid.[59] This reinforced Pakistan's already high fear of encirclement and stoked suspicions that India's intelligence agency, RAW, was bent on stirring up trouble. In addition to concerns that India was using its Afghan consulates as listening posts to gather intelligence, it was an article of faith among the Pakistani security establishment that RAW used Afghanistan as a base from which to support separatists waging a low level insurgency in Balochistan; an allegation Western interlocutors agreed was not unfounded. A former member of the British intelligence community and a British academic who